After the separate groups submitted their reports, their recommendations were rationalized and consolidated. The consolidated report fleshed out the common thread that should prominently run through the separate strategies that the companies falling under each group would implement. Finally, it was concluded that the implementation of a strategic plan should serve two goals. First, it would help the Tatas enter new areas of business and launch major ‘new products’ as, in the past two decades, the Tatas’ record in this area was ‘not seen to be outstanding’. The second would be the establishment of a ‘group mechanism’ to ‘formulate a long-term overall perspective or business direction’ for the Tatas as a whole.

Tragedy Strikes

As 1982 dawned, Ratan’s mother’s health became a matter of concern. She complained of increasing breathlessness and uneasiness. In May, she was taken to the Tata Memorial Hospital in Parel in Bombay for a bronchoscopy. The result, though not conclusive, indicated that she might have cancer. The doctor said that her lungs were weak, which would impact her quality of life, and recommended specialized treatment at Sloan Kettering.

Even before the cancer was discovered, it was suspected that Soonoo had weak lungs. Shireen recalls that her mother had a patch on her lungs, which she assumed was caused by tuberculosis. Soonoo was also a social smoker. Her husband, Sir Jejeebhoy, who had passed away in 1968 due to emphysema was a heavy smoker. Perhaps Soonoo was also adversely affected as a passive smoker, as Ratan says.

In June 1982, Soonoo and Shireen left for the US. Deanna was keen to accompany them, but had to wait for a few days to settle some time-bound legal issues concerning a property. She joined them soon, though. Appointments were made for Soonoo with the doctors at Sloan Kettering. Shireen recalls that Ratan was also with his mother despite his preoccupation with the preparation of the Tata Plan.

Soonoo and he met with the doctors. The diagnosis confirmed their suspicions. Soonoo had lung cancer and it was at an advanced stage. Initially, invasive investigation was advised and later it was decided to insert radioisotopes in the affected lung. Surgery was advised and scheduled for 12 July.